

GIS Intake Assistant

Step 5 – Zoning Ordinance / Setback Source Discovery

Version: v0.2.16

Objective

Expand the GIS Intake Assistant beyond GIS and zoning map discovery by helping identify official zoning ordinance, development code, and setback reference sources relevant to the detected jurisdiction.

The intent is not to calculate setbacks automatically, but to reduce research time by surfacing the most likely official code documents where setback requirements are located.

Features Added

1. Zoning Ordinance / Setback Discovery

Added a third discovery category alongside:

- GIS / Parcel Sources
- Zoning Map Sources
- Zoning Ordinance / Setback Sources

The system now performs additional searches focused on:

- Zoning Ordinances
 - Development Codes
 - Land Development Codes
 - Municipal Codes
 - Setback Requirements
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2. Jurisdiction-Aware Filtering

Search results are filtered using the detected:

- City
- County
- State

This prevents unrelated jurisdictions from appearing in results.

Example:

Detected:

- Grand Junction
- Mesa County
- Colorado

Rejected:

- Garfield County
- Delta County
- Grand Rapids

Results must contain signals matching the detected jurisdiction before being displayed.

3. Official Source Prioritization

The search favors official and code-related sources including:

- .gov websites
- Municode
- eCode360
- American Legal Publishing
- Planning Departments
- Municipal Code Libraries

Preference is given to ordinance and code sources rather than general articles.

4. Noise Reduction

Additional filtering was added to reject common low-value results such as:

- News articles
- Blogs
- LegalMatch
- Social media sites
- Real estate portals
- Word documents (.doc / .docx)

This improves the likelihood that surfaced links contain actual regulatory information.

5. Duplicate Removal

New ordinance and setback candidates are passed through the existing duplicate-removal workflow.

Previously saved sources in the GIS Source Database are excluded from Suggested Sources.

This prevents repeated recommendations of already verified links.

6. Google Sheets Integration

The new feature works with the existing source database architecture.

New source category supported:

- setback_reference

Users may save verified ordinance or setback-related sources directly to Google Sheets using the existing Save Verified Source workflow.

No database structure changes were required.

7. UI Improvements

Additional spacing was added between discovery categories to improve readability.

Current structure:

GIS / Parcel Sources

Zoning Map Sources

Zoning Ordinance / Setback Sources

This creates clearer visual separation during review.

Testing Status

Status: Active Testing

Current evaluation goals:

1. Determine whether ordinance/code discovery consistently surfaces useful jurisdiction-specific sources.
 2. Measure whether this reduces manual Google searching during drafting intake.
 3. Identify jurisdictions where setback discovery performs poorly.
 4. Evaluate whether ordinance-focused discovery is more useful than setback-specific discovery.
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Known Limitations

Setback requirements are rarely published on standalone pages.

In most jurisdictions they are embedded inside:

- Zoning Ordinances
- Development Codes
- Land Development Codes

For this reason, the feature currently prioritizes ordinance and code discovery rather than attempting direct setback extraction.

Future versions may explore:

- Ranking official code providers higher.
- Opening ordinance sources directly to setback-related sections.
- Automated setback table extraction.
- Dedicated setback-reference database entries.

Deployment Notes

After deployment, Streamlit Cloud required the Google Service Account secrets to be re-entered manually.

Application functionality was unaffected.

Only Google Sheets integration was unavailable until secrets were restored.

Issue resolved by re-adding:

`[gcp_service_account]`

to Streamlit Cloud Secrets.